Send In The Clowns

London DIY trio **Gentle Stranger** make a racket to drown out the daily grind. By **Claire Sawers**

Clockwise from left: Tom Hardwick-Allan, Alex McKenzie, Josh Barfoot

"On my birthday three years ago, this crow just walked into my parents' house," says Tom Hardwick-Allan, main lyricist for the absurdist no wave trio Gentle Stranger. "I was in my old bedroom. It came in and hopped up on the bed. It's never left since then. Pretty crazy. That's kind of what it's like to write a song, it comes in through the back door and it's just… there."

The mysterious appearance of that bird – who still lives in Hardwick-Allan's childhood home – could be a metaphor for the South East London group. Menacing but ultimately benign, waddling in like a gentle feathered stranger, the crow's arrival could be interpreted in many ways, or none at all. Much like Gentle Stranger's music: a surreal patchwork of psychedelic electronics, no wave deadpan minimalism and sea shanty love songs, where toy pianos overlap with yelps and wonky sax.

Gentle Stranger's three members are all quick to swap personas and instruments. They started out as "a post clown" duo, with Hardwick-Allan performing in an orange clown's nose found by his dad before he was born. "My dad, who is also a postman, posted the nose to me, which is one possible origin myth of 'post-clown'…", says Hardwick-Allan, an unapologetic fan of nerdy wordplay."There's this central joke in clowning where the clown always dies yet always gets up again," he continues. "We've never had that much money…"

"Or success,", chimes in his multi-instrumentalist bandmate Alex McKenzie. "But we keep going," shrugs Hardwick-Allan.

Along with drummer Josh Barfoot, the trio are perched on McKenzie's bed, surrounded by costumes and musical instruments. I spot a guitar, autoharp and triangle through the Skype window and when McKenzie gets up to let in the photographer, I notice a keyboard and clarinet too. All three take turns to explain *Love And Unlearn*, their sprawling, eccentric 19 song odyssey, which zig-zags between shonky, Beefheartian disco, Balkan folk, and their low budget, over the top live peformances. Full of batshit set pieces, they mash together naive poetics with dense musical textures that are chaotic but often cut through with real sadness.

"We often have way more than we can carry when going to a gig – instruments, costumes and whatever theatrics seem necessary for a particular set," says Hardwick-Allan. "It's usually an absolute mission to get there – none of us can drive. Trekking across the country for festivals over summer was pretty intense and involved 'borrowing' a lot of shopping trolleys."

Surreal lyrics play a key role too, and they've started handing out lyric sheets at gigs. What at first glance could be dismissed as fey gibberish about woodland creatures often conceals something more threatening. "Smoke Alarms" is a quick cacophony of post-punk guitar, squeaking electronics and a bleeping smoke alarm. One short line is faux dramatically sung like a warped "Bohemian Rhapsody", but beneath its bravado lurk jarringly dark mercenary words about replacing people with properties. *"I will replace my friends with/Smoke alarms when I make/Enough to build a house and burn it"*.

Yet unexpected flashes of tenderness beam through their Ivor Cutler style rhymes. In "Love And Unlearn" they sing, *"Love tucks a mollusc back into its shell"*, and elsewhere someone or something is *"Like a deer without eyelids when it comes to love"*. "We don't mean it to be nonsense," swears Hardwick-Allan. "We're actually trying to do something specific, we put a great deal of care into it. There's this kind of clownish defiance about it."

When they're not making music, McKenzie teaches primary school music and works as a session musician, Hardwick-Allan is an artist and Barfoot works in a coffee shop. Their absurd humour may be a response to their own precarious situation, limited by the kinds of special effects they can pull off on a shoestring. Shambolic early shows involved singing, stamping on balloons for percussion, handing out cake, and so on. One time, an improvised budget version of a snow machine blew puffs of talcum powder and went spectacularly wrong. "It's almost set up to fail," says Barfoot, "then the failure is incorporated into it. Our live shows are very much about that. Our set-ups are quite complicated with all the instruments, so something is bound to."

From their no-audience DIY beginnings, over the past five years they have gone on to perform at Supernormal, Green Man and The Great Escape festivals. They describe their first album as "quite teenage in some respects", explaining their music is "like trying to process the world in a real way, even though it's quite overblown and camp". They've almost finished their second album, and elsewhere they've been collaborating with Ectopia's tragi-comic drag diva Adam Christensen on a song for *Solidarity Tapes*, a benefit compilation for grassroots groups fighting for migrant, climate and social justice.

"I suppose the way we operate as a band lets our politics seep in," says Barfoot. "It's a very collective process. We write in Alex's bedroom because we can't afford to hire somewhere. And we like to approach things obliquely so that nothing is fixed, but everything is up for debate. We like to keep an ambiguity, but explore multiple possibilities."

Like on "Call Me Back L8r", a song bouncing with bright brass parps and guttural bassline from their former bandmate Evangeline Ling, who left before the album came out to focus on her other band Audiobooks. The track opens with Hardwick-Allan nonchalantly singing *"I am busy/Shitting my guts out"*, the lyrics descending into misery even as the melody bops along. It turns out that Hardwick-Allan suffers from ulcerative colitis, and the song is rooted in a text he sent to McKenzie from the bathroom on a particularly bad day. "That's definitely one of the sillier ones, but yeah I sometimes shit blood," he shrugs, as the other two erupt in laughter behind him.

"But there's a seriousness beneath the playfulness," he quickly point out. "I guess that's that clownish thing again. You can read it as funny, or really sad. Laughing and crying at the same time, or something like that." ☐

Gentle Stranger's *Love And Unlearn* by is released by PRAH recordings

Guy Bolongaro

Printed for Goldsmiths, University of London from The Wire - April 2020 (Issue 434) at exacteditions.com. Copyright © 2020